



Sound Sleep with Open Source

Sheela Foam, a Ghaziabad-based home and industrial foam products manufacturer, placed its bets on open source and has never looked back, since.

Sheela Foam, a leading manufacturer of slab stock polyurethane foam, has helped millions sleep well, since 1972. Today, it enjoys approximately 35 per cent of the Indian PU foam market and is growing steadily at 25 per cent per annum.

In April 2009, Sheela Foam deployed a Red Hat Enterprise Linux (RHEL) on a Dell PowerEdge server to host its mission critical application called Greatplus—a home-grown ERP solution. Further, it used Linux for its file servers, FTP servers and Web servers. “The Red Hat Enterprise Linux on the Intel Xeon processor-based Dell PowerEdge server system has given me peace of mind by providing stability to our IT infrastructure. This is apart from being well-designed to scale and caters to the rapidly growing demands of our company,” says Pertisth Mankotia, head, IT, Sheela Foam (Sleepwell).

The switch to open source

Prior to hosting IT applications on open source, Sheela Foam had a legacy server on a UNIX environment to automate its entire production process, from procurement to production. “... this made us dependant on the proprietary vendor, preventing us from testing and implementing new features and from scaling effectively. It wasn't our baby, so we were reluctant to

play with it. Further, to preserve our initial investment in the platform, we had to invest considerably in new hardware and licensing fees,” said Mankotia.

Finally, Sheela Foam decided on open source after the legacy server crashed and took almost 16 hours to be up and running again. “In our manufacturing business, time is money. The crash directly affected our ERP system that manages our entire business spectrum, supporting over 3,000 dealers and 70 distributors. If the ERP system stops, business stops. With manpower costs amounting to nearly 40 per cent in our Australian manufacturing unit and about 5 per cent in India, it was a huge loss for us. We urgently felt the need for a reliable and robust platform and decided to look at open source,” says Mankotia.

Thereafter, Mankotia consulted Dell and conducted a trial run of Red Hat Enterprise Linux on the Dell PowerEdge server at its joint ventures—Sheela & Beards and Woodbridge Group—with a load of around 200 users. The high level of performance during the 15-day trial convinced those at Sheela Foam to place its mission critical ERP tool on the platform, shifting 90 per cent of applications and the workload of 1,500 users on to open source.